

Nurturing potential.

Helping every young person succeed in second-level education and navigate a future beyond it.

Name / team _____

Date _____



Who changed your odds?

Think of a repeatable adult practice, not a heroic one-off gesture.

01 What did that adult do repeatedly?

02 What did their behaviour communicate about your ability or future?

03 Which student in your school may not experience that reliably yet?

Boundary: keep the student private. Work with patterns and practices; do not write trauma histories or identifying details.

Hold two truths together.

Inequality is measurable. Individual outcomes are not predetermined.

13.8%

children in child-specific enforced deprivation,
2024

28.3%

DEIS post-primary students missing 20+ days in
responding schools, 2023/24

83.4%

DEIS retention to Leaving Certificate for the 2017
entry cohort

12%

disadvantaged students academically resilient in
PISA 2022

What does this data make you notice?

What must it never make us assume about an individual student?

Rate the student experience, not the policy.

1 = person-dependent or inconsistent · 4 = systematic, visible and reviewed

01	Known	Every student can name an adult who will notice.	☐	☐	☐	☐
02	Taught	Support preserves challenge, subject access and future options.	☐	☐	☐	☐
03	Present	Attendance patterns trigger timely, barrier-responsive support.	☐	☐	☐	☐
04	Partnered	Families can reach a person and leave with a clear next step.	☐	☐	☐	☐
05	Future-ready	Every student can name three plausible routes and next actions.	☐	☐	☐	☐

Strongest promise: _____

Least dependable: _____

Where might student or family ratings differ from ours?

Turn a verdict into a useful question.

Barrier-aware language preserves both accountability and possibility.

VERDICT

“They do not value school.”

BETTER QUESTION

What makes attendance harder here?

“The family will not engage.”

How accessible and trustworthy is our contact?

“Not college material.”

Which routes and supports remain invisible?

“Trauma explains it.”

What supports regulation and a return to learning?

A phrase or assumption we need to examine:

Our more useful question:

Known + taught ambitiously.

Choose routines that make belonging and success less dependent on luck.

KNOWN

- ☐ Named adult with a real check-in routine
- ☐ Fast noticing after absence, withdrawal or change
- ☐ Repair after conflict
- ☐ Strength recorded and carried into support meetings

TAUGHT

- ☐ Model expert thinking aloud
- ☐ Use worked examples and guided practice
- ☐ Check understanding beyond volunteers
- ☐ Feedback creates a next attempt
- ☐ Fade scaffolds toward independent retrieval and planning

ONE ROUTINE TO MAKE DEPENDABLE

Routine: _____

Where / when: _____

How we know it happened: _____

Trauma-aware without becoming trauma-detectives.

Universal safety and predictable practice; targeted support through established systems.

DO

- ☐ make routines predictable
- ☐ offer choice within boundaries
- ☐ regulate before reasoning
- ☐ provide a dignified route back
- ☐ refer and review through the support team

DO NOT

- ☐ collect ACE scores
- ☐ diagnose from behaviour
- ☐ demand disclosure
- ☐ remove all limits
- ☐ replace specialist care

One predictable routine we can strengthen:

Our route for consultation / referral:

Safeguarding: follow school procedures for disclosures or immediate risk. Do not investigate in a classroom or workshop activity.

Notice > ask > map > act > review.

Twenty days is a reporting threshold; support should begin when a meaningful pattern emerges.

01

NOTICE

What changed? When? Which pattern?

02

ASK

What does the student say? The family?

03

MAP

Barrier, strength, resource, risk

04

ACT

One specific response and owner

05

REVIEW

Date, evidence, adapt / escalate

Plan the first contact.

Specific · curious · strength-first · accessible · reliable

STRENGTH

What can we truthfully name first?

PATTERN

What specific days, changes or work have we noticed?

QUESTION

How will we ask what may be getting in the way?

NEXT STEP

What small action can school and home agree?

FOLLOW-THROUGH

Who will report back, through which channel, and when?

Build three routes, not one prediction.

Each route needs requirements, deadlines, costs/funding, a named adult and a next action.

ROUTE A

Aspiration / CAO / higher education

Course / role: _____

Next action: _____

Funding / access: _____

Adult / date: _____

ROUTE B

FET / PLC / tertiary / access / foundation

Course / role: _____

Next action: _____

Funding / access: _____

Adult / date: _____

ROUTE C

Apprenticeship / work + training

Course / role: _____

Next action: _____

Funding / access: _____

Adult / date: _____

☐ HEAR / DARE checked where relevant

☐ SUSI / costs discussed

☐ Entry requirements verified

☐ Family understands the routes

Leah: separate what is known from what is assumed.

Strong orally · inconsistent written work · 16 absences by February · caring responsibilities · physiotherapy aspiration

KNOWN

Only the information actually given.

ASSUMED

What might we be adding to the story?

What do we need to learn from Leah and home?

What changes tomorrow?

What changes this term?

Who owns each next step?

Design one 90-day test.

Small enough to implement · important enough to matter · specific enough to learn from

PROMISE

Which experience will become more dependable?

FOCUS

For whom, where and when is the gap most visible?

ROUTINE

What will adults do differently, and how often?

OWNER + SUPPORT

Who coordinates? What capacity or training is needed?

EARLY SIGNAL

What should move within four weeks?

LAGGING OUTCOME

Which attendance, learning, retention or progression measure matters?

REVIEW DATE

When will the team learn, adapt or stop?

Will the plan survive Monday?

Use this before the team commits.

- ☐ The change is a visible adult routine, not only a value statement.
- ☐ The owner has authority, time and support.
- ☐ The plan fits existing DEIS / SSE / student-support structures.
- ☐ Students and families can shape or test the approach.
- ☐ We know what we will stop or simplify to create capacity.
- ☐ We can see implementation within four weeks.
- ☐ No sensitive trauma history or diagnostic guess is collected.
- ☐ There is a review date and permission to adapt or stop.

ONE SENTENCE PLAN

For _____, we will
 _____, led by _____,
 and by _____ we expect
 _____.

The open-door standard.

Keep this page. Use it in year-head, subject-department, student-support and leadership meetings.

KNOWN

01

- Name the adult.
 - Notice change quickly.
 - Repair after conflict.
-

TAUGHT

02

- Keep the ceiling high.
 - Model the hidden steps.
 - Feedback creates another attempt.
-

PRESENT

03

- Act before 20 days.
 - Ask before assuming.
 - Review the small plan.
-

PARTNERED

04

- Strength before concern.
 - Make contact accessible.
 - End with one agreed step.
-

FUTURE-READY

05

- Map A, B and C.
 - Check funding and access.
 - Name the adult and deadline.
-

Monday: _____ Owner: _____

Review date: _____

Recheck pathways and statistics before reuse.

Figures and eligibility rules change. The links below are the primary starting points.

CSO child deprivation	https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silccd/silcmoduleonchilddeprivation2024/keyfindings/
Tusla attendance 2023/24	https://www.tusla.ie/uploads/content/Analysis_of_School_Attendance_Data_2023-24.pdf
DEIS Strategy to 2035	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-education/publications/deis-strategy-to-2035/
OECD PISA Ireland 2022	https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/pisa-2022-results-volume-i-and-ii-country-notes_ed6fbcc5-en/ireland_01173012-en.html
HEA socioeconomic profiles	https://hea.ie/statistics/data-for-download-and-visualisations/students/widening-participation-for-equity-of-access/socio-economic-profiles-2021-22-2023-24/student-profile/
ESRI teacher relationships	https://www.esri.ie/publications/how-are-childrens-academic-self-concepts-their-parents-expectations-and-their
NEPS resources	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-education/collections/national-educational-psychological-service-neps-resources-and-publications/
HEAR	https://accesscollege.ie/hear/how-do-i-apply/eligibility-criteria/
SUSI	https://www.susi.ie/eligibility-reckoner-app-irish/index.html
Apprenticeships	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-further-and-higher-education-research-innovation-and-science/services/become-an-apprentice/

Evidence note: trauma-informed school evidence is still developing. This toolkit prioritises role-clear, low-risk practices aligned with NEPS and does not support ACE screening or diagnosis by school staff.